VACANCY NOTICE - 2026-JRC.D.5-IPR-FGIV-002892

Project Officer – Spatiotemporal data scientist to monitor agricultural practices

Type of contract	Member of the European Commission's contract staff, Function Group IV (article 3b of the Conditions of Employment of Other Servants)
Duration of contract	36 months (renewable up to maximum 6 years)
Area	Agriculture
Place of employment	Ispra (IT)
Indicative basic salary	4.449,31 - 6.444,59 € (applicable as of 1st of July 2025) For more detailed information please consult: Working Conditions

WE ARE

The Joint Research Centre (JRC) provides independent, evidence-based knowledge and science, supporting EU policies to positively impact society.

The current vacancy is in the **Directorate for Sustainable Resources**. The Directorate science, positioned at the crossroads of the environment, economy and society, coupled with scientific networks across the EU and beyond, informs policies to ensure that present and future generations enjoy a sustainable planet.

The vacancy is in the **Food Security Unit.** The Unit cross-disciplinary science provides independent evidence in support of EU policies on agriculture and international development. We support the monitoring and implementing of the CAP and help assess the environmental and climate impact of land-based polices, agricultural production, food security, nutrition and food system sustainability in a European and global context, thereby enabling the transition to sustainable food systems and facilitating efficient reporting.

The successful candidate will join the Land Unit Characterization for Policies Team of the Food Security Unit, which provides technical and methodological support to other Commission Services and to Member State (MS) administrations in the context of the Common Agricultural Policy (CAP). We carry out scientific research and provide advice in the development of land monitoring systems exploiting remote sensing and in situ data.

We offer:

We offer high-quality working conditions in a dynamic environment and in a multidisciplinary and multicultural team. The JRC encourages team working environment that includes interactions with policy makers, academics and other leading stakeholders active in the field, including participation in (international) conferences and workshops, as well as occasional travel.
Please see also Working at the Commission – conditions and environment (europa.eu)

WE PROPOSE

A challenging and rewarding post in the Land Unit Characterization for Policies (LUChaP) team, which provides technical and methodological support to Member State (MS) administrations through the development of their land monitoring processes. The post is for a data scientist with experience on geo-spatial analysis and deep learning approaches who will contribute to the development of methodologies for the monitoring of agricultural practices mainly in the framework of the Common Agricultural Policy (CAP). The next CAP policy phase foresees a broadening of the scope of the CAP technical components to a wider set of application contexts to which this post may contribute. Derived contributions to Measurement, Reporting, and Verification (MRV), certification or benchmark processes are also expected.

Agricultural monitoring is mainly based on Earth Observation (EO) data, such as those from the freely available Sentinel-1 and 2 products. The goal of this data scientist position is to contribute to the development of methodologies supporting automatic characterisation of agricultural land conditions, leveraging the use of AI in the integration of satellite imagery, such as those from Copernicus Sentinel satellites, open access data set from EU Member States and field level images taken by drones or mobile devices as well as the any relevant contextual information including administrative data and farmer's declarations on agricultural practices.

The developed methodologies must be robust and validated at scale, ideally across the whole EU territory to capture landscape variability. The research underlying the methodological developments is expected to be published in peer-reviewed journals, released as open-source code, and upscaled for use in operational context by different partners, in particular the CAP paying agencies across the EU MSs.

The developed methodologies will capitalise on the state-of-the-art data science and Artificial Intelligence (AI) techniques for extracting meaningful information mainly from satellite and drones' imagery. The research will be conducted on cloud platforms, such as, but not limited to, the Copernicus Data Space Ecosystem (CDSE), providing access to large EO data collections.

WE LOOK FOR

The ideal candidate should have the following **essential** requirements:

- PhD degree or, alternatively, MSc degree plus 5-year professional experience, in a scientific field dealing with geospatial data and image processing with application in agriculture or other field related to land and environmental monitoring.
- Hands-on experience on programming languages for data science (Python, R or equivalent) and experience with high-performance computing and AI infrastructure is required.
- Ability to draft technical documents as evidenced by relevant scientific publications is essential.
- Very good knowledge of English (level C1).

The following is **desirable**:

- Experience in engaging with stakeholders/end-users.
- Knowledge of EU policies such as the Common Agricultural Policy is an asset.

HOW TO APPLY

If you are **already on a valid CAST FG IV reserve list**, or you **have already applied to one of the calls below**, you can directly submit your application at JRC Recruitment Portal.

If not, before applying to this position, **you must register** for one of the two following databases:

- the Call for Expressions of Interest | EU Careers (europa.eu) (CAST Permanent FG IV), which is used by a wide range of organisations (institutions, bodies, offices and agencies of the European Union), or
- the call for researchers (JRC Call COM/1/2015/GFIV – Research), which is mainly used by the JRC.

Note that each of the calls above has **different minimum eligibility requirements and different selection tests**.

The JRC cultivates a workplace based on respect for other people and the environment, and embraces non-discriminatory practices and equality of opportunity. In case of equal merit, preference will be given to the gender in minority.